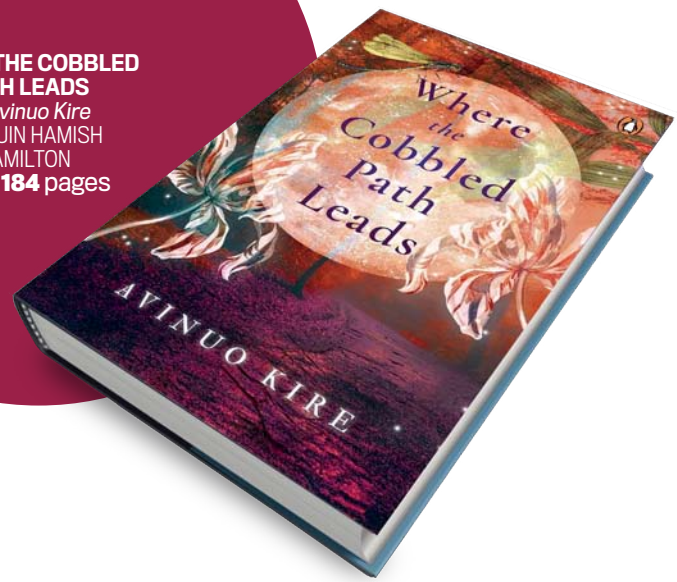
WHERE THE COBBLED PATH LEADS
by Avinuo Kire
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
₹**499; 184** pages



BOOKS

Spirited Away

In **Avinuo Kire's** assured new novel, magic trumps realism by curing profound grief and repairing loss

It is her mother's first death anniversary, and Vime, a young schoolgirl, sadly walks down her favourite crumbling, cobbled path, past the old village gate into the surrounding fields where a majestic old tree stands. Here she falls down, and then goes to sleep. When she awakens, to her bewildered dismay, the path is not where it ought to have been. A lost and alarmed Vime is directed back to the path by Tei, an elfin girl who suddenly appears. Tei takes her hand and walks her around the tree, to the path right where it was earlier, but Vime had not found it in her searching.

The solitary and sad Vime returns to the spot a few days later, drawn there by a forest song, and again meets Tei, who tells her that the tree is Kijubode, the portal between the human world and what lies beyond. A sceptical Vime discovers that she might in fact be telling the truth; Tei herself is no ordinary human but a spirit, and she shows Vime a glimpse of her departed mother, whom Vime misses very much.

Avinuo Kire's novel *Where the Cobbled Path Leads* traces the story of Vime and her struggle with grief, loss and change in a world where the supernatural lies a short walk down a familiar path. Its characters are Tei, Kijubode and other inhabitants of the spirit world—and Vime, her worldly elder sister Neime, her father, friends and neighbours. The real world here is one where Naga separatist militants and search parties of the Indian Army are just around the corner, or perhaps knocking at the door.

The magical elements are drawn from Naga folklore. They hark back to myths that clothed the natural world in stories of talking trees, animals such as were-tigers, and spirits. Such tales long existed around the world. Norse mythology speaks of a great tree of life called Yggdrasil. Greek myths tell of female spirits called nymphs that inhabit trees and water bodies. The Scottish Highlands are thick with tales of a variety of magical beings. Every region of India has its own unique spirit worlds.

The real world in Kire's novel is one where militants and the army's search parties are just around the corner



As modernity stripped away the enchantment of the world, those stories receded, but the hunger of the human mind for magic is evidently undiminished—which is why we lap up *Harry Potter*, *Game of Thrones*, *Lord of the Rings*, *Star Wars*, *Narnia* and all the superhero franchises. The closest of these to spirit tales from folklore is perhaps the unique magic realism in the charming films of the Japanese master Hayao Miyazaki.

There is now a growing body of Naga magic realism that draws upon the oral traditions of the region's old pre-Christian past. Easterine Kire, for one, wrote a fantastic tale of a world of spirits and humans in her novel *When the River Sleeps*. Avinuo Kire's latest book is a part of this emerging genre. It is written in evocative prose, with a strongly fleshed out central character in Vime. The narrative voice is the one weakness of this otherwise fine book; it occasionally becomes rather too professorial, marked by words such as "discombobulate" that leave the reader a tad...discombobulated.

Suspense about Vime's eventual fate, however, is a strong narrative hook, and readers will probably find themselves engrossed until the last page, swept along by the magic. ■

–Samrat Choudhury